



LORDS ON TRIAL

Under mounting pressure, the Supreme Court judges decide to reveal their assets but radical reforms are required in the judiciary to restore credibility and accountability

By Shafi Rahman

It's not often that a full meeting of the Supreme Court takes place but when 23 honourable judges of the apex court met in the evening of August 26, the atmosphere was both tense and uneasy. By the time it dispersed two hours later, the judges had taken a significant step backwards. After months of stonewalling, they finally agreed to demands that they must, like politicians and other public servants, disclose their assets. The climbdown is expected to pull the curtain down on the unseemly wrangle over the contentious issue that has split the legal fraternity down the middle and set the executive against the highest echelons of the judiciary.

Led by Chief Justice of India K.G. Balakrishnan, the judges had for long been under attack from within the higher judiciary for not veering around to the idea of putting their assets in the public domain. Ultimately, it was pressure from within that forced the apex court collegium to backtrack. The standoff would have perhaps continued for long had not a couple of judges

VACANCIES IN COURTS

The shortage of judges runs from top to bottom

	Sanctioned Strength	Vacancies
Supreme Court	31	7
High Courts	886	234
District and Subordinate Courts	16,721	2,998